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CAREER SEGMENTATION RESEARCH

Careers Portfolio for the Association of Allan Gray Fellows

August 2025

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1. Executive summary

This research report explores how the Careers Portfolio of the Association of Allan Gray Fellows can improve its offering. Specifically, the report gives the results of a rapid voluntary survey of Allan Gray Fellows, a set of key informant interviews, as well as a literature review. The key overall question was to assess how viable it would be to segment Fellows for different offerings by using different metrics (e.g. industry, study background, career stage, seniority level, entrepreneurial intent, etc.). In addition, it was to get a snapshot of Fellows' rankings of career goals, preferred support formats (e.g. coaching, networking, skills–building, etc.) The major finding here is that Fellows in various industries and educational backgrounds have similar career support needs, but the surveyed Fellows (mostly new/early graduates) have a slightly higher tendency towards desire self-focused interventions such as mentorship and coaching, and increasing their earning potential. There is also a notable degree of difficulty being experienced by certain newer Fellows, especially those in the social sciences.

Another driving question was to use the literature and the experiences of a peer organisation to get insights on how segmentation works.

The main findings here were from the Africa Careers Network linked to the African Leadership Academy (which was supported by the literature). The key idea is to set up a 'customer relationship management' (CRM) style system that suits the organisations needs and the overall structure and strategy of the Careers Portfolio. This system should be used to identify a set of key high-engagement segments of Fellows, not necessarily to capture all Fellows' career needs. This is to ensure focus of implementation.. The CRM is "kicked off" using an onboarding survey. Then offerings are iteratively designed and tailored to focus on segments of Fellows similar on three axes: career stage, preferred engagement mode (communications vs. experiential) and career aspirations and needs. These iterations are made both on programmatic features like budget and strategy cycles, but also on the continuous feedback from participants on the value they are getting.

2. Introduction & Background

This report explores research conducted to understand how the Careers Portfolio of the Association of Allan Gray Fellows can better serve Fellows. Specifically, it explores what career support needs and wants Allan Gray Fellows have, given their aspirations, their individual and common traits, the professional contexts they face as well as the broader mission of the Association and the AGGP group and ecosystem.

The report takes as its starting point the fact that Fellows are highly motivated, passionate and talented individuals which comes with both the benefits and pressures. Fellows are selected and then nurtured to make an entrepreneurial impact in their societies. It also considers that the Careers Portfolio already has a suite of offerings that it delivers to Fellows.

The research specifically looks at how a “segmentation” approach could be used to better target Fellows given their different career journeys: which differ in terms of career-stage, industry, and specific challenges. A segmentation approach would have many benefits. It would help to target different forms of career support, and ensure the actions that facilitate support, e.g. appropriate and timely communications, events, personnel, etc. are also more targeted. It would ensure that it would help to identify efficiencies that might be gained where many Fellows have the same type of needs.

From a methodology perspective, the research took the form of a survey of Allan Gray Fellows, delivered using email and community channels. The research also included semi-structured key informant interviews of key persons within and outside the Association ecosystem. The key information interviews were designed to extract insights about best practice.

This methodology took as its starting point that the Association already collects information about Fellow engagement with specific programmes through its End-of-Year Survey. Thus the survey collected information that would specifically inform what “segments” could look like.

2.1. Context and purpose

The mission of the Association for Allan Gray Fellows is to “foster an active community of Allan Gray Fellows who are further inspired, motivated and developed to become high impact responsible entrepreneurs”.[1] The aim of the Careers Portfolio is to “provide life-long learning opportunities and professional development for Fellows [through] guidance, support and career-focused opportunities that align to entrepreneurship.”[2]. This is, in part, achieved by guiding Fellows.

2.2. Research questions & research methodology

The research questions explored by the research report were:

2.2.1. What do Fellows want in terms of career support, in relation to characteristics like: life-stage, career-stage, industry entrepreneurial intent and their availability.

2.2.2. What are best practices for delivering career support, specifically using a segmentation approach?

3. Summary of Literature Review

This literature summary focuses on the most relevant insights on the literature on (i) principles of segmentation and (ii) career development theory. The insights from the alumni segmentation literature suggest segmentation that focuses on three axes: **Career Stage**, **Preferred Engagement Mode** & **Career Aspirations.** The insights from career development theories which are valuable for giving cross-cutting themes that work best for broad, medium-term career support activities such as MasterClasses or mentorship.

3.1. Principles of segmentation

Segmentation is about grouping Fellows on relevant variables to inform targeted intervention[3]. The literature from other alumni segmentation interventions shows that effective programmes

[1] Association Playbook and Strategy 2024, page 4. Association of Allan Gray Fellows
[2] Association Playbook and Strategy 2024, page 33. Association of Allan Gray Fellows
[3] Straujuma et al., “Alumni Segmenting for Fostering Innovation and Entrepreneurship in Universities.”

are those that cluster programme participants *specifically on the* variables that strongly predict engagement and service needs. The first major point is career segmentation should be done to *focus* on a targeted set of Fellows interested who show active interest in getting support from Careers Portfolio. This could be ascertained by means of a baseline survey.

The next major step is to segment the Fellows. The suggestion is on three axes.

Three key axes relevant to the Careers Portfolio are: (i) Career stage, (ii) Preferred engagement mode and (iii) Career and entrepreneurial aspirations. The first axis, Career Stage is quite obvious.[4] This refers to the core information about Fellows' career stage, industry and seniority level. This information is the descriptive information captured in End-of-Year surveys, and that can be collected especially from a special Careers Portfolio "onboarding survey".

The second axis is Engagement Mode. A key framework is CASE's "Four Modes of Engagement.[5] The CASE model suggests first dividing participants into modes of preferred engagement (only three are relevant) viz those who prefer (i) *communications* (e.g. emailed job offerings) versus those who engage (ii) *experientially (e.g.* events and workshops) versus those who want to be in *volunteer* roles. The suggestion is to *deep-dive into the specific needs and wants of those who have a preferred engagement mode,* rather than to use overall data to inform interventions. For example, it is better to ask focused questions to those who *strongly prefer events & workshops* like MasterClasses about their needs, *instead of* planning MasterClasses based on what seems like a general need. Likewise, those interested in *communications* e.g. job opportunities should be asked specific questions about their industries, etc. to help the Careers Portfolio build industry partnerships.

The third axis would be Career and Entrepreneurial Aspirations. This involves getting Fellows to answer questions about their career goals & preferred support modes

[4] Straujuma et al., "Alumni Segmenting for Fostering Innovation and Entrepreneurship in Universities," 31.
[5] BrightCrowd, "Understanding the CASE Four Modes of Alumni Engagement"; Council for Advancement and Support for Education, "Alumni Engagement Metrics That Matter | CASE."

3.2. Implementing segmentation

The literature on audience segmentation (as well as the key informant interviews) suggest a "CRM" based approach where baseline data on the following is collected and maintained on the above three axes.

Core profile: graduation year, degree, sector, location—already exists in the Association databases.

Preferred engagement: between communications vs. experiential vs. volunteer/community.

Engagement ledger: event attendance, mentorship hours.

Psychographic indicators: entrepreneurial intention, preferred support mode, give-back motivation. This is gathered with brief Likert-scale items (e.g. rank this support type on a scale of 1-5).

3.3. Career Development Theories

The field of career development theories has evolved past and builds on top of the traditional focus on "matching" a person to a certain industry or job-type based on their personality.[6] [7] and skills. Listed below are some key aspects from more recent theories that are relevant to the unique traits that Fellows are selected for.

One aspect is a focus on *career adaptability*, which is a focus on the "interpersonal" process of crafting meaning to their careers, connecting careers to a deeper "why" and crafting stories and "future-scenarios" to increase career adaptability.[8] *Career adaptability* speaks to having a future focus, a sense of agency, curiosity and confidence - so that people can handle career tasks,

[6] McDaniel and Snell, "Holland's Theory and Occupational Information."
[7] Cardello et al., "Bringing Theories to Life in the Classroom: Super's Life Span Life Space Theory."
[8] Savickas and Savickas, "Vocational Psychology, Overview."

transitions, and shocks.

Similarly, another key aspect is the joint role of *self-efficacy,* having accurate *outcome expectations* and *contextual support*.[9] A nice summary is that career navigation involves persisting through challenges by strengthening what is inside you (self-efficacy) , what is in front of you (outcome expectations) and what is around you (contextual support).

A third key aspect is the role of *planned happenstance*[10] *and the "chaos"*[11] element in career journeys. These frameworks argue that cultivating curiosity, persistence and risk-taking lets people capitalize on unplanned events; and that building resilience in small, rapid ways can counter volatility.

These key aspects ought to be cross-cutting themes in career support offerings due to their alignment to entrepreneurial values of the Foundation.

4. Research methodology

4.1. Overview of survey design

The survey was designed to give initial insights on what career support segments make sense for the Fellow population, and to answer the other main research questions. The sections of the survey were divided as follows.

The survey asked demographic questions that tracked respondents' graduation years, fields of study, location, employment status, industry/sector, years of experience, seniority level, and employment satisfaction and entrepreneurial intent.

The survey then asked questions about respondents' most important career goals; their appetite for a *set list* of career support interventions. The survey assessed respondents' ranking of the following career support interventions: job search strategies, getting direct job opportunities, expert-led *training* like MasterClasses, *information* sessions*,* networking opportunities with *experts*, networking opportunities with Fellows, Fellow-based topic-specific peer groups,

[9] Dziak, "Social Cognitive Career Theory (SCCT) | EBSCO Research Starters."
[10] Truyens, "Planned Happenstance Learning Theory - Krumboltz & Levin."
[11] Pryor and Bright, "(PDF) The Chaos Theory of Careers."

mentorship, *paid* custom courses that are organised by the Association but paid for by Fellows).

The next batch of questions assessed respondents' preferences for *communication* for career related updates. The questions looked at communication *channels and* communication *frequency*. The survey also asked about willingness to participate in Fellow activities.

Finally, the survey included an *open-ended section* for respondents to provide more detail on specific *challenges* they faced in their careers; as well as specific *support* they would like from the Careers Portfolio, and to name specific *obstacles.*

4.2. Survey dissemination

The survey was disseminated through multiple channels. It was sent via the official Association email channel on two occasions, via the Whatsapp channels (during Weekly Digest); at fellow career events including the New Fellows Career Connect workshop; as well as through personal Whatsapps through a referral system.

4.3. Data analysis

Due to the MCQ-based design of the survey, quantitative data were analysed using multi-response frequency analysis. These included mean/average rating across Likert scales, and chi-squared test of association between demographic variables and the Top Career Goals.. Additionally, a set of chi-square tests was run to test whether the demographic variables (Industry, Cohort, Seniority Level) are correlated to variables like Top Career Goals.

4.4. Limitations of the survey

The survey had a significantly higher number of MCQs, and only a few written response questions. This was done to ensure a higher response rate, and because past engagements by the researchers showed that Fellows tend to answer open-ended questions with answers that show very specific concerns they are dealing with at that moment, not so much with broader

career concerns that could be bundled with other responses to give systematic insights. This guess was borne out in the main survey.

The survey was voluntary, and so only gives insights for those who are very engaged, or those who see career navigation as a current pain point.

The respondents skew towards younger Fellows.

The literature suggests a more robust “segmentation approach” needs much more detailed survey responses. These would best be done as part of a full-on onboarding of those who want to go through a more committed career development journey, e.g. something mimicking the IVC/EA programmes. Participants would need to be assessed on their psychometric “fit” to certain industries, their current career navigation resources (e.g. their networks) etc.

5. Research Findings

5.1. Key Survey Respondent Demographics

- The survey received 143 respondents. The majority of respondents are more recent grads, meaning the insights skew towards younger Fellows. This is influenced by the fact that more recent Fellows are more likely to be engaged with Association activities more generally, would have more incentive to fill in the survey due to higher levels of career uncertainty or a higher need for career support.

- The majority of survey respondents are in full time employment.

- Respondents were mainly in the finance, commerce and investment sector

5.2. Key Survey Findings

Demographic variables e.g. Grad Year, Industry, Employment Status, Seniority Level (e.g. being in a junior, mid-level or senior management roles) were measured and compared to segmentation variables e.g. Top Career Goals, preferences for career support Channels, preferences for Frequency of engagement (how much time people have available for engagement with the Career Support portfolio).

Research finding	**Analysis**
Which potential segments correlate with specific Top Career Goals? Of all the demographic variables, **Seniority Level (i.e. whether they are junior, mid-level or senior employees)** was the only one where there was **strong statistical correlation** between the different levels and the Top Career Goals support needed. Beyond this, the Top Career Goals people face are fairly consistent across other demographic variables. This implies respondents (in this sample) all have similar career goals and activity preferences.	Overall, this was likely caused by a high subsample of recent graduates. However, this shows that there are no specific Career Goals that correlate to Industry, or Years since Graduation. **Recommendation:** The overall programme and offerings should be designed in a way that can accommodate Fellows with different demographics

	being involved in the same Career Goal e.g. industry-agnostic mentors and industry-agnostic MasterClasses.
What Career Goals were most important ● The top selected Career Goals were, in ranked order: Increasing Earning Potential, Developing New Skills or Competencies, Technical Skills, Leadership Development, Communication, Career Advancement, Increased Responsibility. Expanding Professional Networks.	Of the Career Goals options given in the survey, there seems to be a higher tendency towards Career Goals that are “self-focused” and “tangible” This is opposed to goals that are more ‘social’ i.e. connecting with others, or growing in a company. This reflects broader research that younger workers care less about ‘loyalty’ or growth within a company or an industry. They are focused on their own path. Recommendation: These types of goals are usually supported by formal programmes, and usually have a cost implication.
Career Support Types When asked to score different forms of Career Support from 1 to 5, the given options all scored in the medium to high range, meaning they are highly valued.	**Analysis & Recommendation** The higher relative preference for Mentorship, 1-on-1 sessions and MasterClasses may imply that Fellows want to be supported on a journey. They likely do not even have clarity on the specifics of what it means and what it takes to navigate a

The highest average scores were for Mentorship (4.2), 1-on-1 sessions with a coach.	career successfully. **Recommendations:** If possible, the programme needs ways to show a “map” of what career navigation even entails. The segmentation programme must show Fellows the different parts of navigating a career. This is opposed to relying on Fellows to ask for what they need.
Frequency of communication preferences The survey asked how often people want to be contacted for career related activities. They were asked to select **two options**, since one of the options was “it depends”. The other options were once a quarter, once a month, two events in a year, one event in a year. When responses were combined, 38.5% said it really depends on the activity; 28.9% indicated it once a quarter and 21.4% indicated once a month.	**Analysis & Recommendations**. This implies a preference for tailored comms , but general communications, once a quarter feels adequate.

Communication channel preferences	**Analysis & Recommendation**
The survey asked what channels people wanted to be communicated on. Options were given for email, newsletter, a Whatsapp community, social media and other. The most preferred channel: **was email with a 46%** rate followed by a newsletter at 28%. Whatsapp was preferred at only 17% followed by other social media at 7%.	Email is the most preferred channel. Other channels, such as Whatsapp would only be valuable if there was some long-term specific *community of practice* being built e.g. a “Make the Leap” Whatsapp group, for Fellows who have made the decision to quit their jobs and go into full-time entrepreneurship within a year. Channels like this would need the participants and coordinators to brainstorm specific rules and setup beforehand.
Willingness to contribute to the Association in volunteer roles Respondents were asked their willingness to participate in career-related activities in volunteer roles. The results: Yes in general (open to any role)- 34.1% Unsure/maybe in the future - 11.8& Mentorship - 10.4% Guest-speaking panels -10.1% Sharing job opportunities - 9.4%	**Analysis and Recommendations** The recommendation is to make participation and sign up for this quite easy. This could be done using the general onboarding form, but Fellows would be asked quite early in the form whether they just want to volunteer for career-related activities, and then they can leave their relevant details there.

5.3. Summary of key informant interviews

A number of key informant interviews were held. The key respondents included: the Community Manager of the Careers Portfolio; the Alumni Manager and the Careers Network Manager from the African Leadership Academy ecosystem; and shorter interviews with members of the Association Executive.

Numerous attempts were made to source other informants and focus group participants but these were unsuccessful.

Key theme: Reflections on overall purpose of the Careers Portfolio & its value to Fellows

- The Careers Portfolio has had high uptake in the recent period. Fellows have derived a lot of value from the current offerings such as the job offerings, 1-on-1 sessions, and the Startership event.
- Newer Fellows have a strong entrepreneurial intent. However, many new fellows are grappling with how to navigate their career.
- A number of new Fellows (especially those from the social sciences background) are having a significantly harder time: they are facing unemployment, and feel they have significant gaps in crafting CVs, poor interviews, etc.
- Many Fellows (again especially from the social sciences) want to pivot and want to know what transferable skills they need to attain

Key theme: Experiences/best practice with segmentation

- Data gathering and management is central. It should start as soon as feasible
- The value of a CRM (customer relationship management) system that collects data on specific participants and their needs. The idea is that since career journeys are highly stylised, it is better to collect various types of data over time, and then iteratively see what interventions are needed for participants.

- Partnerships: Two key informants suggested that building close partnerships with companies in different industries was very important to the work they do.
- Partnerships: Relationships with Employer-Partners should not be transactional, but should be values-driven. One way of ensuring this is having a “90 minute onboarding session for employer-partners outlining values and expectations
- Focused data must be collected on stakeholders (e.g. companies who want to hire Fellows) to get a deeper sense of what they want from prospective Fellows (*and what they have GAINED from Fellows they have onboarded)*

6. Key overall recommendations & conclusions

This section takes all the findings of the report and condenses them into the main ideas that answer the research questions.

6.1. The research questions for this report were:

6.1.1. What do Fellows want in terms of career support, in relation to characteristics like: life-stage, career-stage, industry entrepreneurial intent and their availability?

- The Fellows represented directly in the survey, and those indirectly through key informant interviews have a variety of career goals. The highest ranking Career Goals form a cluster that implies Fellows are anxious to just do well and improve in their own individual prospects in the spaces they are in. Many new Fellows are struggling in their roles, and are even struggling to find work.

  The Careers Portfolio should have an overall view of structuring programmes that help guide (new) Fellows along a journey. Especially a journey that improves their career adaptability, their self-efficacy; improving their resilience. These themes tie in very well with the overall goal of encouraging Fellows to enter

entrepreneurship.

- At this stage, the surveyed Fellows seem to only want communications that are specifically relevant to them (implying segmentation) and they want general communications about Career Support about once a quarter.

6.2. What are best practices for delivering to career support, specifically using a segmentation approach?

6.2.1. Segmentation axes

Three key axes for segmentation are:

6.2.1.1. Career Stage and the Fellow's core profile;
6.2.1.2. The Fellows' Preferred Engagement Mode whether it is (i) communications; or (ii) experiential.
6.2.1.3. Career and entrepreneurial aspirations (based on Fellows' on ranking of different pre-determined types of career support, as well as what they self-indicate. entrepreneurial intention, preferred support mode, give-back motivation.

6.3. Implementing the segmentation using a "CRM" system

The literature indicates a CRM system. There are various available options for this including free versions such as Hubspot, Salesforce or Airtable.

This system should be used to identify a set of key high-engagement segments of Fellows, not necessarily to capture all Fellows's career needs. This is to ensure focus of implementation. The CRM is "set up" using an onboarding survey. The survey results are used to segment Fellows on three axes: career stage, preferred engagement mode (communications vs. experiential) and career aspirations and needs.

The decision for the specific CRM system should be based on:

6.3.1. a strategic decision on how critical the “segmentation approach” will be for the Career Portfolio’s strategy. If it is deemed very critical, then higher functionality is needed

6.3.2. a decision on capacity to manage the system

7. References

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8. Appendices

8.1. Appendix I: Selected Graphs

The figures below were derived from the survey discussed above.

The figure below ranks the top career goals that fellows have:

Figure 1: Top Career Goals

In terms of Frequency of engagement, the survey asked how often people want to be engaged on career related updates. This was to ascertain whether respondents want continuous engagement or a tailor-made or “opt-in” experience. Most respondents preferred “opt-in” style engagements, and the next highest response was to be engaged “once a quarter”. The figure below indicates this:

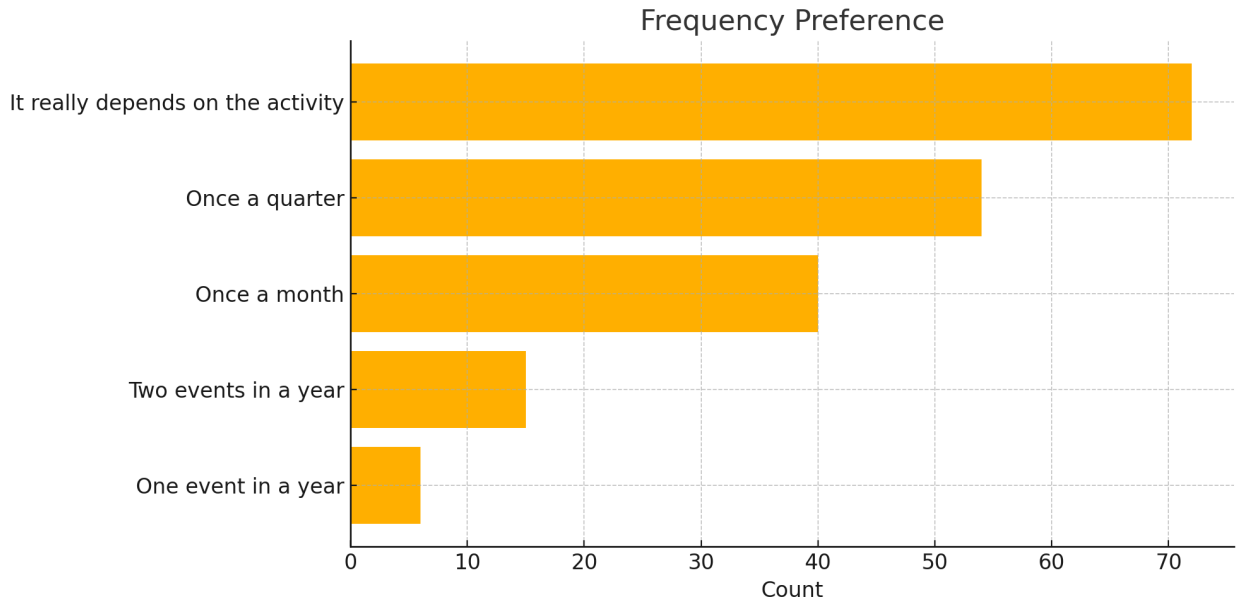

Figure 2: Engagement frequency preference

The figure below indicates the fellows' graduation year:

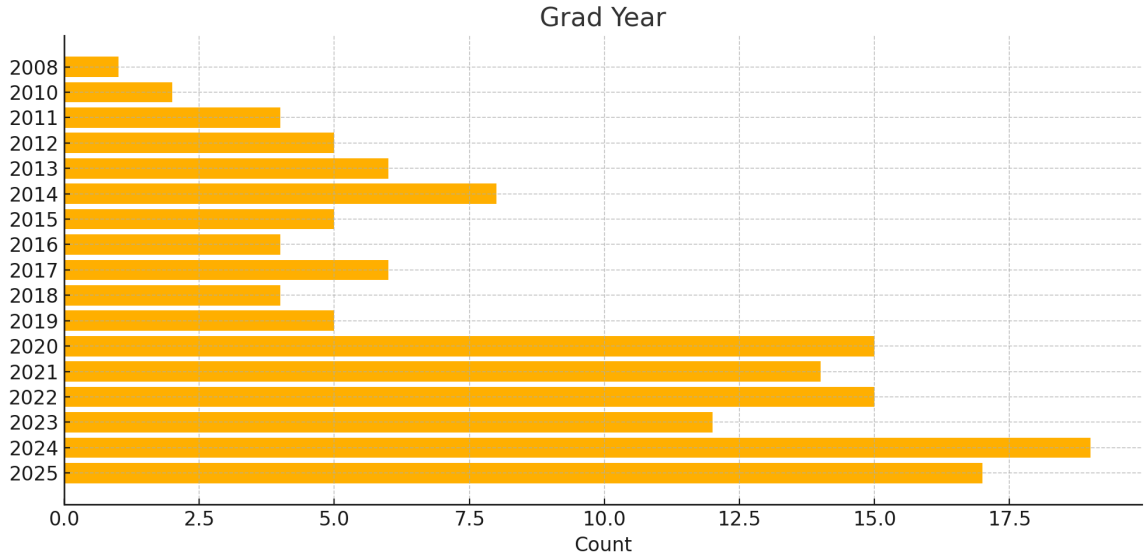

Figure 3: Fellows' graduation year

The majority of respondents are more recent grads, especially those who graduated after 2020.

The figure below shows the fellows' preferred channel of communication:

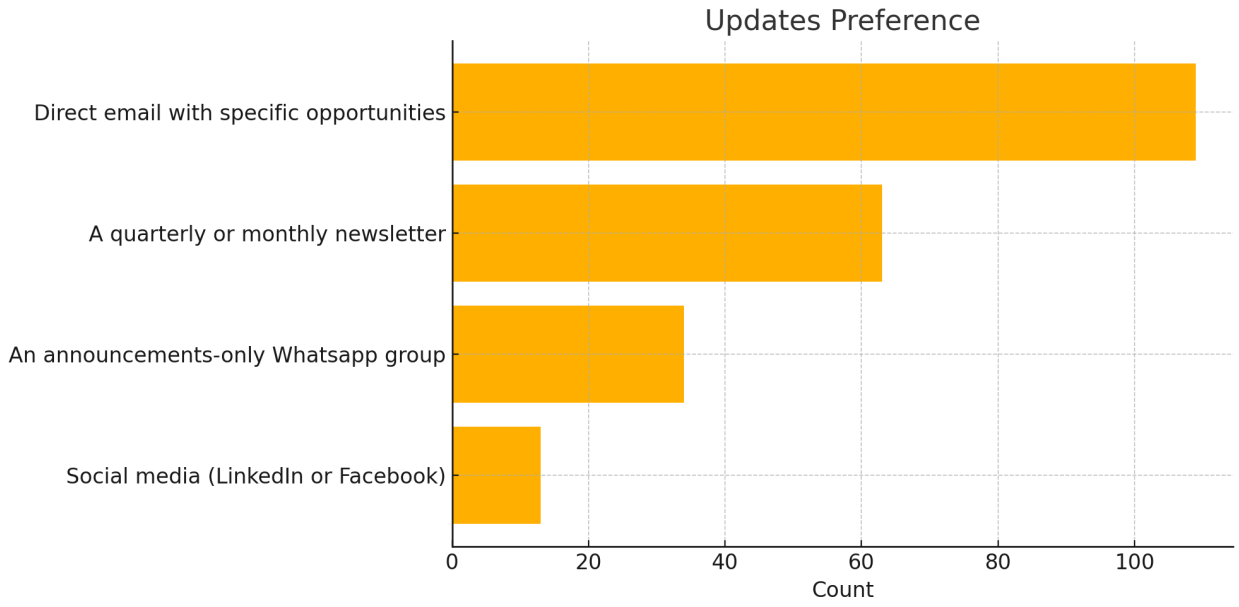

Figure 4: Preferred communication channel

The table below shows the ranking of other questions in the survey:

Table 1: Career support type ranking

Career Support Type	Avg Score (out of 5)
Mentorship	4.22
1-on-1 sessions with a coach	4.17
Expert-led MasterClasses (i.e. trainings)	4.06
Job search strategies (e.g., resume/CV review, interview prep)	3.93
Networking opportunities with experts	3.93
Networking opportunities with Fellows	3.84
Info sessions with experts	3.72
Fellow-based peer group for specific issues	3.59
Direct job opportunities sent to me	3.38
Custom courses, paid for by me, organised for groups of Fellows	3.21

Appendix II: Structure and timing of onboarding survey and update survey

Onboarding survey

Survey Section	Purpose & Structure
1. Personal & Professional Info	Capture identity, cohort, employment status, seniority, and industry.→ *Short text + dropdowns*
2. Career Situation & Goals	Ask about career satisfaction and top goals.→ *Likert scale + multi-select (with ranking)*
3. Support Triggers	Ask about current blockers (e.g. lack of network, job market access, unclear path).→ *Multi-select + optional text*
4. Preferred Support Formats	Identify how they prefer to engage (masterclass, mentorship, networking, async content, etc.)→ *Multi-select + commitment-style question (e.g. "Would you sign up for this in the next 3 months?")*
5. Communication Preferences	Ask for channel (email, WhatsApp, etc.), frequency, and type of content (invitations, opportunities, highlights).→ *Multi-select + Likert*
6. Willingness to Contribute	Recruit potential mentors, speakers, opportunity-sharers. Offer concrete options.→ *Multi-select + short text if "Other"*

Cyclical survey

Survey Section	Purpose & Structure
1. Quick Status Check	Track changes in employment, satisfaction, and goals since last time.→ *Dropdowns + sliders (0–10 satisfaction scale)*
2. Immediate Career Need	Ask: "What's your biggest current need in your career?"→ *Single-select with option to write in*
3. Upcoming Support Interest	Check interest in support offerings coming up: mentorship, events, exposure, upskilling.→ *Multi-select + opt-in checkbox*
4. Format & Timing Preference	Ask preferred time slots (weeknight, weekend), and engagement style (async vs live).→ *Multi-select*
5. Feedback on Past Engagement	Ask: "Did you find any previous AGOF careers support helpful?" + quick NPS-style rating (i.e. "*Would your recommend the Careers Portfolio to a Fellow in your position?".→ Yes/No + short text*
6. Contribute or Collaborate?	Re-ask contribution question, especially if someone recently advanced or expressed interest.→ *Multi-select + optional text*